

KARNATAKA & TAMIL NADU ORIGIN

Masala Dosa

Crispy Fermented Crepe with Spiced Potato Filling
South India's Most Iconic Breakfast Dish

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Masala Dosa

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Masala Dosa

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Crepe That Conquered a Continent

Few dishes have crossed linguistic and cultural boundaries the way masala dosa has. Originating in the coastal temple towns of Karnataka — Udupi in particular — the masala dosa began as a temple prasadam food, a simple fermented batter pancake served at dawn to pilgrims and priests. Its journey from temple kitchen to every street corner and five-star hotel breakfast buffet in India is one of the most remarkable stories in South Asian culinary history.

The transformation from plain dosa to masala dosa — with a spiced potato filling — is credited to the Udupi Brahmin community, whose strict vegetarian traditions and instinct for flavour layering produced what is now perhaps the most recognised Indian breakfast dish in the world. The word 'masala' refers to the spiced potato mixture (aloo masala) that lines the inside of the dosa, perfumed with mustard seeds, curry leaves, turmeric, and ginger.

Today, masala dosa exists in dozens of regional and restaurant forms — from the slender, paper-thin set dosa of Bengaluru's Military Hotels to the enormous, almost translucent 'paper masala dosa' of Chennai's Saravana Bhavan. What unites them all is the same fundamental formula: a perfectly fermented batter, a fiercely hot tawa, and a filling that elevates a simple pancake into a complete meal. It is the dish that defines South Indian breakfast to the world.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Crepe That Conquered a Continent, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

The flagship item of every Udupi-style restaurant in India — a dish ordered more than any other on the South Indian tiffin menu. The batter is identical to idli batter, making the two dishes natural partners in any home kitchen; one batch of batter serves both. In Karnataka, a red chilli-garlic chutney (the 'red chutney') is smeared on the inside of the dosa before the filling — a detail that distinguishes the Karnataka version from Tamil Nadu's more coconut-chutney-forward service. Masala dosa was introduced to the United Kingdom in the 1970s by South Indian restaurant owners and is now among the top five most recognised Indian dishes in the world. It is served as far afield as New York, Sydney, and Dubai as a defining symbol of South Indian cuisine.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

6–8h	12–16h	20m	40m	6 (12 dosas)	Medium
SOAK TIME	FERMENT TIME	MASALA PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Heavy cast iron tawa or flat griddle (minimum 30 cm diameter)
- High-powered wet grinder or powerful blender (for smooth batter)
- Large bowl or vessel (4 litre capacity) for fermenting the batter
- Ladle with a flat-backed bowl (for spreading the dosa in circles)
- Offset or thin flat spatula for releasing and folding the dosa
- Kadai or deep pan for cooking the aloo masala

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Batter keeps refrigerated for 4–5 days; the flavour improves over the first 2 days. The aloo masala can be made 1 day ahead and refrigerated — reheat gently before filling. Cooked dosas must be eaten immediately; they lose their crispness within minutes and cannot be stored. For advance preparation, par-cook the dosa to 70% done, cool, stack with parchment between layers, and refrigerate up to 4 hours — finish on a hot tawa to order.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the masala dosa

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Parboiled (idli) rice	1½ cups	285 g	1½ katori
Raw rice (sona masoori or basmati)	½ cup	95 g	½ katori
Urad dal (split black gram, skinned)	½ cup	95 g	½ katori
Chana dal (split chickpeas)	1 tbsp	12 g	1 tbsp
Fenugreek seeds (methi)	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	1 chammach
Oil or ghee (for cooking)	2–3 tsp per dosa	10–15 ml	2–3 chammach

For the potato masala (aloo masala)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Potatoes, boiled and roughly mashed	4 medium	500 g	4 medium
Oil	2 tbsp	28 ml	2 tbsp
Mustard seeds	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Urad dal (for tempering)	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Chana dal (for tempering)	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Fresh curry leaves	12–15	12–15	12–15
Green chillies, slit	3	3	3

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the potato masala (aloo masala) (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Onion, finely sliced	2 medium	200 g	2 medium
Fresh ginger, grated	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste
Fresh coriander, chopped	3 tbsp	12 g	3 tbsp
Lemon juice	1 tbsp	15 ml	1 tbsp

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Parboiled rice gives the dosa its characteristic crispness and golden colour — do not replace it entirely with raw rice. Urad dal is non-negotiable for fermentation and texture. Fenugreek seeds aid fermentation and add a very subtle bitterness that rounds the batter's flavour; use up to 1 tsp if the climate is cool and fermentation seems slow. For the potato masala, waxy potatoes (like Yukon Gold) hold their texture better than floury varieties; a mixture of roughly mashed and whole small pieces gives the best texture. The Karnataka red chutney (dried red chillies, garlic, coconut, tamarind) can be added to the inside of the dosa before the filling for an authentic Karnataka-style masala dosa.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Batter Preparation & Fermentation

01 SOAK THE RICE AND DAL

Combine the idli rice, raw rice, and chana dal in one large bowl. In a separate bowl, combine the urad dal and fenugreek seeds. Rinse both bowls well, then cover with plenty of cold water and soak for 6–8 hours (or overnight). Keep the urad dal separate — grinding them separately is essential for a light, airy batter.

Chef tip. Cold water soaking produces a slightly firmer batter that gives crispier dosas; room temperature soaking is faster but the batter tends to be slightly softer. If making dosas next morning, soak at night in the refrigerator.

02 GRIND THE URAD DAL FIRST

Drain the urad dal and fenugreek. Add to a blender or wet grinder with a few tablespoons of cold water and grind until completely smooth — the batter should be white, light, and slightly airy, almost like a thick cream. This takes 8–10 minutes in a blender (scraping down regularly) or 20 minutes in a wet grinder. Transfer to a large fermentation vessel.

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Batter Preparation & Fermentation, continued

Chef tip. Cold water (or even ice water) in the blender prevents the motor heat from heating the batter, which would damage the fermentation cultures. Add water very gradually — the urad dal batter should be thick and fluffy, not pourable.

03 GRIND THE RICE

Drain the rice and chana dal. Grind with water until fairly smooth but with a very slightly grainy texture (this is deliberate — some texture aids crispness). Add to the urad dal batter and mix thoroughly with a clean hand to incorporate air. Add salt and mix again.

04 FERMENT THE BATTER

Cover the vessel loosely (not airtight — the batter must breathe) and leave to ferment at room temperature for 12–16 hours. In a warm climate (above 28°C), 12 hours is sufficient; in a cooler kitchen, allow up to 18 hours. The batter is ready when it has doubled in volume, smells pleasantly sour, and has a slightly bubbly surface.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Batter Preparation & Fermentation, continued



COOKING CHECKPOINT

Properly fermented batter is the foundation of a great masala dosa. Signs of correct fermentation: volume has doubled; a spoonful dropped in water floats; the surface is slightly bubbly and domed; the aroma is pleasant and faintly sour, never off or pungent. Under-fermented batter will not spread evenly and produces a pale, soft dosa. Over-fermented batter is too sour for a standard masala dosa — redirect it for uttapam.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

The Aloo Masala & Cooking the Dosa

05 COOK THE ALOO MASALA

Heat oil in a kadai over medium-high heat. Add mustard seeds; wait for them to pop, then add urad dal and chana dal and fry until golden. Add curry leaves, green chillies, and sliced onion. Fry for 4–5 minutes until the onion is soft and translucent. Add grated ginger and turmeric and fry for 1 minute. Add the roughly mashed potatoes and salt; mix thoroughly to combine with the tempering. Cook for 2 minutes, then add lemon juice and fresh coriander. Keep warm.

Chef tip. Leave some potato pieces slightly chunky — a mixture of mashed and small whole pieces gives the masala the best texture and prevents it from becoming an undifferentiated paste.

06 HEAT THE TAWA AND SET THE BATTER

Heat the tawa over high heat for 3–4 minutes until very hot. Drizzle a few drops of oil across the surface. Take a ladle of batter and pour onto the centre of the tawa. Working quickly, use the back of the ladle in a smooth spiral motion from the centre outward to spread the batter into a thin, even circle — 25–30 cm. The entire spreading motion should take 3–4 seconds.

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The Aloo Masala & Cooking the Dosa, continued



Chef tip. The first dosa almost always fails. It is used to season the tawa and is discarded. From the second dosa onward, the tawa is at the correct temperature and the dosa will spread and release cleanly.

07 COOK TO GOLDEN AND CRISP

Drizzle a teaspoon of oil or ghee around the edges and over the surface of the dosa. Cook on medium-high heat for 2–3 minutes without moving until the edges turn golden, the surface is matte, and the dosa releases cleanly from the tawa. The dosa should be uniformly thin and golden with slightly darker edges. Do not flip a masala dosa.

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The Aloo Masala & Cooking the Dosa, continued

Chef tip. Ghee instead of oil at this stage gives a restaurant-quality richness and a deeper golden colour. Add a small knob of ghee at the edges — it sizzles and crisps the border.

08 FILL AND FOLD

Spoon 2–3 tablespoons of warm aloo masala along the centre line of the dosa. Fold one side over the filling, then the other — like a loose cylinder or half-moon. Alternatively, roll tightly into a cigar shape (the Bengaluru style) or leave flat open-face (the Tamil Nadu style). Slide onto the serving plate and serve immediately.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

A masala dosa that sits on the plate for more than 90 seconds loses its crispness. The tawa must be at temperature when filling, and the dosa must go from tawa to table in one fluid movement. Never fill and stack dosas — they steam each other and lose their crunch.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



The Classic Trio

- Served with coconut chutney (ground coconut, green chilli, ginger, tempering of mustard and curry leaves) and sambar — this combination is non-negotiable for an authentic masala dosa.
- The Karnataka version includes a third chutney: a red garlic-chilli chutney smeared directly on the inside of the dosa before the filling, adding heat and depth.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Accompaniments

- A small steel tumbler of filter coffee served alongside masala dosa is the quintessential South Indian breakfast pairing.
- Tomato chutney or a green coriander-mint chutney are acceptable variations but not the traditional service.

Restaurant Style

- Paper masala dosa — spread tissue-thin across the entire tawa and folded paper-crisp — is the restaurant showpiece version.
- Ghee masala dosa: an extra pour of ghee during cooking gives the dosa a richer, slightly softer golden colour favoured in upmarket hotel breakfasts.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

The Tawa Wipe Technique

- Between each dosa, wipe the tawa with a clean cotton cloth or halved onion to remove residue and reset the surface temperature. A residue-free tawa at the correct temperature ensures every dosa from first to last is equally good.
- If the tawa gets too hot, splash a tiny amount of water on it and immediately wipe — this drops the temperature without requiring time off the flame.

Batter Temperature

- Batter straight from the refrigerator spreads unevenly and produces pale, thick dosas. Always bring batter to room temperature for 20–30 minutes before cooking.
- Stir the batter gently from the bottom before each ladle — the heavier rice settles and the batter must be re-homogenised for a consistent spread.

THE PERFECT MASALA

The aloo masala should be just slightly wetter than mashed potato — a mixture that spreads easily into the dosa rather than clumping. If too dry, add 2 tablespoons of hot water and mix.

Cashews fried in the tempering oil before the mustard seeds, then stirred into the masala, is the hotel breakfast finishing touch that elevates home masala dosa to restaurant level.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

280 kcal	7 g	42 g	9 g	3 g
CALORIES (PER MASALA DOSA)	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with preparation method and serving size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Paper Masala Dosa	Spread to the maximum possible thinness — almost translucent in places — and cooked extra-crisp. The showpiece of Tamil Nadu restaurants; requires a very hot tawa and confident spreading.
Ghee Masala Dosa	An extra tablespoon of ghee poured over the dosa while cooking and mixed into the filling — richer, softer, and distinctly more aromatic. The 'hotel style' version.
Open Masala Dosa	The masala filling is placed in the centre and the dosa is served flat, without folding — the Chennai presentation style that shows the golden surface and filling simultaneously.
Paneer Masala Dosa	Grated paneer mixed into the aloo masala or used as a replacement — a modern restaurant innovation that adds protein and richness.
Egg Masala Dosa	A beaten egg poured over the dosa just before filling and allowed to cook on the surface — a street-food variation popular in North Indian South Indian restaurants.

My dosa is sticking to the tawa and tearing when I try to spread it – what's wrong?

Almost always a temperature problem. The tawa must be very hot before the first pour (water drops evaporate in under 1 second) and at the correct medium-high heat for spreading. A sticky dosa also occurs with a tawa that has not been properly seasoned. Wipe the tawa with oil, heat again, and try the next pour.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

My dosa batter didn't ferment – it's the same volume after 16 hours. What do I do?

Low kitchen temperature is the most common cause. Move the batter to the warmest spot in the house (near the oven, on top of the refrigerator) or place the covered vessel in an oven with just the light on (30–35°C). Do not use warm water in the batter — it must be cold at the start of fermentation. Allow another 4–6 hours.

Can I make a dosa on a non-stick pan?

Yes, but the result is noticeably different — a non-stick pan produces a paler, softer dosa rather than the deep golden-brown crispness of a cast iron tawa. Non-stick is a good training tool for beginners but not for the full restaurant-quality experience.

Why does my masala dosa lose its crispness so quickly?

A dosa that goes cold even briefly loses crispness permanently. The only solutions are: eat immediately after cooking, or cook to order at the table using a portable induction plate. Covering a dosa to 'keep warm' is the worst thing to do — the steam destroys the crust within seconds.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Tawa	a flat Indian griddle; cast iron gives the best crispness for dosa; seasoned with oil over many uses to develop a non-stick surface.
Urad dal (skinned)	the split, husked black gram that gives dosa batter its characteristic lightness, white colour, and fermentable properties.
Fermentation	the natural process by which wild yeast and bacteria acidify and leaven the batter over 12–16 hours; warm kitchens ferment faster than cool ones.
Aloo masala	the spiced potato filling; 'aloo' means potato in Hindi; the filling that transforms a plain dosa into a masala dosa.
Karnataka red chutney	a thick paste of dried red chillies, garlic, and tamarind; the defining difference between a Karnataka-style and Tamil Nadu-style masala dosa.
Parboiled rice (idli rice)	rice that has been partially boiled in the husk before milling; it gives dosa its characteristic golden colour and crispness.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Masala Dosa

6–8h SOAK TIME	**12–16h** FERMENT TIME
20m MASALA PREP	**40m** COOK TIME
6 (12 dosas) SERVINGS	**Medium** DIFFICULTY

MASALA DOSA

Parboiled	285 g
Raw rice	95 g
Urad dal	95 g
Chana dal	12 g
Fenugreek seeds	1.5 g
Salt	6 g
Oil or ghee	10–15 ml

POTATO MASALA (ALOO MASALA)

Potatoes	500 g
Oil	28 ml
Mustard seeds	3 g
Urad dal	3 g
Chana dal	3 g
Fresh curry leaves	12–15
Green chillies	3
Onion	200 g
Fresh ginger	4 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Salt	to taste
Fresh coriander	12 g
Lemon juice	15 ml

METHOD

01 **Soak the rice and dal.** Combine the idli rice, raw rice, and chana dal in one large bowl.

02 **Grind the urad dal first.** Drain the urad dal and fenugreek.

03 **Grind the rice.** Drain the rice and chana dal.

04 **Ferment the batter.** Cover the vessel loosely (not airtight — the batter must breathe) and leave to ferment at room temperature for 12–16 hours.

05 **Cook the aloo masala.** Heat oil in a kadai over medium-high heat.

06 **Heat the tawa and set the batter.** Heat the tawa over high heat for 3–4 minutes until very hot.

07 **Cook to golden and crisp.** Drizzle a teaspoon of oil or ghee around the edges and over the surface of the dosa.

08 **Fill and fold.** Spoon 2–3 tablespoons of warm aloo masala along the centre line of the dosa.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Parboiled	285 g	☐ Raw rice	95 g
☐ Urad dal	see recipe	☐ Chana dal	see recipe
☐ Fenugreek seeds	1.5 g	☐ Salt	see recipe
☐ Oil or ghee	10–15 ml	☐ Potatoes	500 g
☐ Oil	28 ml	☐ Mustard seeds	3 g
☐ Fresh curry leaves	12–15	☐ Green chillies	3
☐ Onion	200 g	☐ Fresh ginger	4 g
☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g	☐ Fresh coriander	12 g
☐ Lemon juice	15 ml		

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